

UNIVERSITY OF ESSEX

Second and Third Year Examinations 2002

SC301-3-SP: CURRENT DISPUTES IN SOCIOLOGY: SOCIOLOGICAL ANALYSIS III

Time allowed: 2 hours

Candidates must answer **TWO** questions.

The paper consists of 5 questions

Please do not leave your seat unless you are given permission by an invigilator

Do not communicate in any way with any other candidate in the examination room.

Do not open the question paper until told to do so.

All answers must be written in the answer book(s) provided and not on rough paper.

At the end of the examination, remain seated until your answer book(s) have been collected and you have been told you may leave.

Leave your scrap paper on the desk when you leave the examination room.

1. **EITHER:**

- a. Can sociology be scientific?

OR:

- b. 'Whatever the strengths of critical realism as an account of natural science, it is irrelevant to the study of society.' Discuss.

2. **EITHER:**

- a. Can sociology improve on the understandings that participants in social life already have?

OR:

- a. Could we ever be justified in making moral judgements about other cultures?

3. Weber and Habermas both distinguish between different sorts of rationality. Where do they differ?

4. What is meant by 'standpoint epistemology'? Can it provide a basis for deciding between rival approaches in sociology?

5. **EITHER:**

- a. To what extent does a poststructuralist approach imply giving up a critical standpoint on society?

OR:

- b. Can there be such a thing as knowledge for emancipation?

END OF PAPER

UNIVERSITY OF ESSEX

Second and Third Year Examinations 2002

SC301-3-FY: CURRENT DISPUTES IN SOCIOLOGY: SOCIOLOGICAL ANALYSIS III

Time allowed: 3 hours

Candidates must answer **THREE** questions: **ONE** from section A, **ONE** from section B, and **ONE** from **either** section

The paper consists of 11 questions

Please do not leave your seat unless you are given permission by an invigilator

Do not communicate in any way with any other candidate in the examination room.

Do not open the question paper until told to do so.

All answers must be written in the answer book(s) provided and not on rough paper.

At the end of the examination, remain seated until your answer book(s) have been collected and you have been told you may leave.

Leave your scrap paper on the desk when you leave the examination room.

SECTION A

1. Critically discuss the view that new mobilities criss-crossing societal borders 'hold out the possibility of a major new agenda for sociology' (John Urry).
2. **EITHER:**
 - a. Judith Butler sets out to destabilize fixed and natural notions of gendered identity. How successful is she in this?

OR:

- b. What are the problems of essentialist notions of identity? How does post-structuralist theory address these problems?
3. **EITHER:**
 - a. In what ways, if any, was Foucault a post-structuralist?

OR:

- b. Was Foucault's understanding of power an advance over Marxist approaches?
4. What are the implications of the postmodern attack on notions of reality, truth and identity in the social sciences?
5. **EITHER:**
 - b. Are we living in a new communications age? Discuss the ways in which the Internet has brought new life to the debate on new forms of social and cultural interaction.

OR:

- b. How far and in what ways have contemporary western societies been transformed as a result of technological changes in the last half-century?
6. Discuss the strengths and weaknesses of: (a) reflexive modernity; (b) late capitalism and (c) postmodernity as characterisations of contemporary western societies.

SECTION B

7. **EITHER:**

a. Can sociology be scientific?

OR:

b. 'Whatever the strengths of critical realism as an account of natural science, it is irrelevant to the study of society.' Discuss.

8. **EITHER:**

a. Can sociology improve on the understandings that participants in social life already have?

OR:

c. Could we ever be justified in making moral judgements about other cultures?

9. Weber and Habermas both distinguish between different sorts of rationality. Where do they differ?

10. What is meant by 'standpoint epistemology'? Can it provide a basis for deciding between rival approaches in sociology?

11. **EITHER:**

a. To what extent does a poststructuralist approach imply giving up a critical standpoint on society?

OR:

b. Can there be such a thing as knowledge for emancipation?

END OF PAPER